Milkweed, Idaho's Most Useful Perennial Vegetable

Asclepias speciosa is a western species of milkweed that grows in areas of low elevation across Idaho and surrounding states. Its range spans from the west coast to Minnesota; from New Mexico to Manitoba. The Snake River Plain is home to millions of stands of this plant. You've probably seen milkweed before: round, pink flowers along the fence lines in the valleys that turn to spiky pods in July or August, only to burst open with hundreds of seeds attached to white filament by the end of September. Many people regard this plant for its ancient relationship with Monarch Butterflies. However, few know it for the abundance of food that it provides throughout the spring and summer.

Before we get into seasons and preparations, it's worth noting that milkweed is toxic when it's raw. It has glycosides and natural latex, both of which are denatured by cooking. I have eaten lots of milkweed and never experienced any issues. Just cook it, and there is nothing to worry about. The same thing goes for many "normal" foods such as sweet potatoes.

Edible Parts and Harvest



Milkweed provides us with food starting in early spring, when the shoots begin to appear. This, in my opinion, is the most delicious phase, and it can last up to two months. To know if the milkweed is still in its shoot phase, try to break it off as you would a carrot or asparagus. If it snaps cleanly without much effort, it is good to eat. The reason you would not want to eat older milkweed stalks is because they are so fibrous that it would be hard to enjoy them. Milkweed shoots are more or less interchangeable with asparagus in cooking. However, before roasting or frying, I always blanch them for at least one minute. This improves their color, flavor, and texture. You can cut about half the shoots in a good patch of milkweed. They will grow one or two more shoots off of each one that is cut.

The next edible phase conveniently occurs right after the shoots become too tough to eat. The flower buds will start to form in late spring or early summer. You can harvest the flower buds and the top 4 leaves and think of them as wild broccoli. Like the shoots, you can harvest about half of the buds from each patch. Remember to blanch them first, but then cook them however you want.

The next phase of harvest is completely different than any of the others: the flowers. They bloom in mid to late summer, and you can't miss them. There is a reason one of the common names of this plant is "Showy Milkweed." The flowers are best used to make syrup or jelly. I recommend making cheong with them, and mixing the cheong with sparkling water to make milkweed soda.

The last edible phase of harvest, is the pods. When the pods are young and tender, usually when they are 3 inches (8cm) long or less, you can cook them as you would any other part of the plant. You can also make milkweed pickles with these, and with the shoots, but they are best eaten fresh. Leave some pods to go to seed so that more milkweed patches can form.

Make sure to check Appendix A for details on all of these preparations.

Tending and Propagation

Milkweed forms long-lived perennial patches, sometimes lasting decades. With tending and harvesting, these patches can continue to expand. Milkweed is a vital plant to Monarch Butterflies. Responsible harvest ensures food for both you and yours, and the Monarchs. Remember to harvest only up to half of a patch. Actively plant more milkweed to expand the patches from which you harvest, or start a new patch. Milkweed is very easily propagated by seed. In the early autumn, gather the seeds from the dry pods and plant them wherever you'd like milkweed to appear, in about ½ inch (1cm) of dirt. Wait a few years before you harvest milkweed that you have grown from seed.